

A GRAIN AS BIG AS A HEN'S EGG

A. Before you read :

- 1) Every day you eat rice and chapati. Have you seen a grain of rice / wheat ? How big are these grains ?
- 2) Ask your parents / grandparents about the size of the grains during their time.
- 3) Imagine the size of a grain as big as hen's egg. Where does it grow, and who grows it ? Why can't we grow that size of grains in our fields ?
- 4) Discuss in groups and note down the ideas.

Now read the following story to know more about the grains which are as big as hen's eggs.

B. Text :

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One day some children found, in a raving, a thing shaped like a grain of corn, with a groove down the middle, but as large as a hen's egg. A traveller passing by saw the thing, bought it from the children for a penny, and taking it to town sold it to the king as a curiosity.

The King called together his wise men, and told them to find out what the thing was. The wise men pondered and pondered and could not make head or tail of it till one day, when the thing was lying on a window-sill, a hen flew in and pecked at it till she made a hole in it, and then every one saw that it was a grain of corn. The wise men went to the king and said : 'It is a grain of corn'.

At this the King was much surprised; and he ordered the learned men to find out when and where such corn had grown. The learned men pondered again, and searched in their books, but could find nothing about it. So they returned to the King and said :

'We can give you no answer. There is nothing about it in our books. You will have to ask the peasants; perhaps some of them may have heard from their fathers when and where grain grew to such a size.

So the King gave orders that some very old peasant should be brought before him; and his servants found such a man and brought him to the King. Old and bent, ashy pale and toothless, he just managed with the help of two crutches to totter into the King's presence.

The King showed him the grain, but the old man could hardly see it; he took it, however, and felt it with his hands. The King questioned him, saying :

'Can you tell us, old man, where such grain as this grew ? Have you ever bought such corn, or sown such in your fields?'

The old man was so deaf that he could hardly hear what the King said, and only understood with great difficulty.

'No He answered at last. ' I never sowed nor reaped any like it in my fields, nor did I ever buy any such. When we bought corn, the grains were always as small as they are now. But you might ask my father. He may have heard where such grain grew.

So the king sent for the old man's father, and he was found and brought before the King. He came walking with one crutch. The king showed him the grain, and the old peasant, who was still able to see, took a good look at it. And the King asked him:

'Can you not tell us, old man, where corn like this used to grow ? Have you ever bought any like it, or sown any in your fields ?'

Comprehension check :

1. What did the children find in the ravine ?
2. How did the wisemen know that was a grain of corn ?
3. What did the king do to collect information about the grain ?
4. Could the learned men find out the answer ? What was their suggestions ?
5. What was the king's question to the old peasant who came first?

6. Was he able to hear and see ? What was his answer ?
7. How did the old peasant's father come to the king ? Was he able to see ?
8. The king asked the same question to the old man's father. Now goes what could be his answer, will he be able to recognise the grain ? Let's read the remaining part of the story to know when exactly these grains were harvested.



Though the old man was rather hard of hearing, he still heard better than his son had done.

'No', he said, "I never sowed nor reaped any grain like this in my field. As to buying, I never bought any, for in my time money was not yet in use. Every one grew his own corn, and when there was any need, we shared with one another. I do not know where corn like this grew. Ours was larger and yielded more flour than present-day grain, but I never saw any like this. I have, however, heard my father say that in his time the grain grew larger and yielded more flour than ours. You had better ask him."

So the king sent for this old man's father, and they found him too, and brought him before the king. He entered walking easily and without crutches: his eye was clear, his hearing good, and he spoke distinctly. The king showed him the grain, and the old grandfather looked at it, and turned it about in his hand.

'It is long since I saw such a fine grain', said he, and he bit a piece off and tasted it.

'It's the very same kind', he added.

'Tell me, grandfather, said the 'King', 'When and where was such corn grown ? Have you ever bought any like it, or sown any in your fields ?'

And the old man replied :

‘Corn like this used to grow everywhere in my time. I lived on corn like this in my young days, and fed others on it. It was grain like that we used to sow and reap and thrash’.

And the king asked :

‘Tell me, grandfather, did you buy it anywhere, or did you grow it all yourself?’

The old man smiled.

‘In my time’, he answered, ‘no one ever thought of such a sin as buying or selling bread; and we knew nothing of money. Each man had corn enough of his own.’

‘Then tell me’, grandfather, asked the king, where was your field, where did you grow corn like this ?’

And the grandfather answered :

‘My field was God’s earth, wherever I ploughed, there was my field. Land was free. It was a thing no man called his own. Labour was the only thing men called their own.’

‘Answer me two more questions, said the King. ‘The first is, why did the earth bear such grain then and has ceased to do so now ? And the second is, why your grandson walks with two crutches, your son with one, and you yourself with none? Your eyes are bright, your teeth sound, and your speech clear and pleasant to the ear. How have these things come about ?’

And the old man answered :

‘These things are so, because men have ceased to live by their own labour and have taken to depending on the labour of others. In the old time they lived according to God’s law. They had what was their own, and coveted not what other had produced.

Leo Tolstoy

Comprehension check :

- 1) How big was the corn in his fathers time ?
- 2) Read the lines that describe the old man's grand father.
- 3) What was the grandfather's reply to the king's question ?
- 4) Did the people in grandfather's time buy or sell bread ?
- 5) Was the land free during his time ? Say the lines that suggest.
- 6) What were the last two questions of the king ?
- 7) What reply did the grandfather give ?

C. Glossary :

Ravine	:	a very deep narrow valley .
grove	:	a long, narrow, deep line cut in a surface.
pondered	:	thought carefully
ashy pale	:	unhealthy
totter	:	to walk in unsteady way.
thrash	:	to beat repeatedly
have taken to	:	are attracted to / liked to
coveted	:	strong desire to have something that belongs to others.

D. Writing :

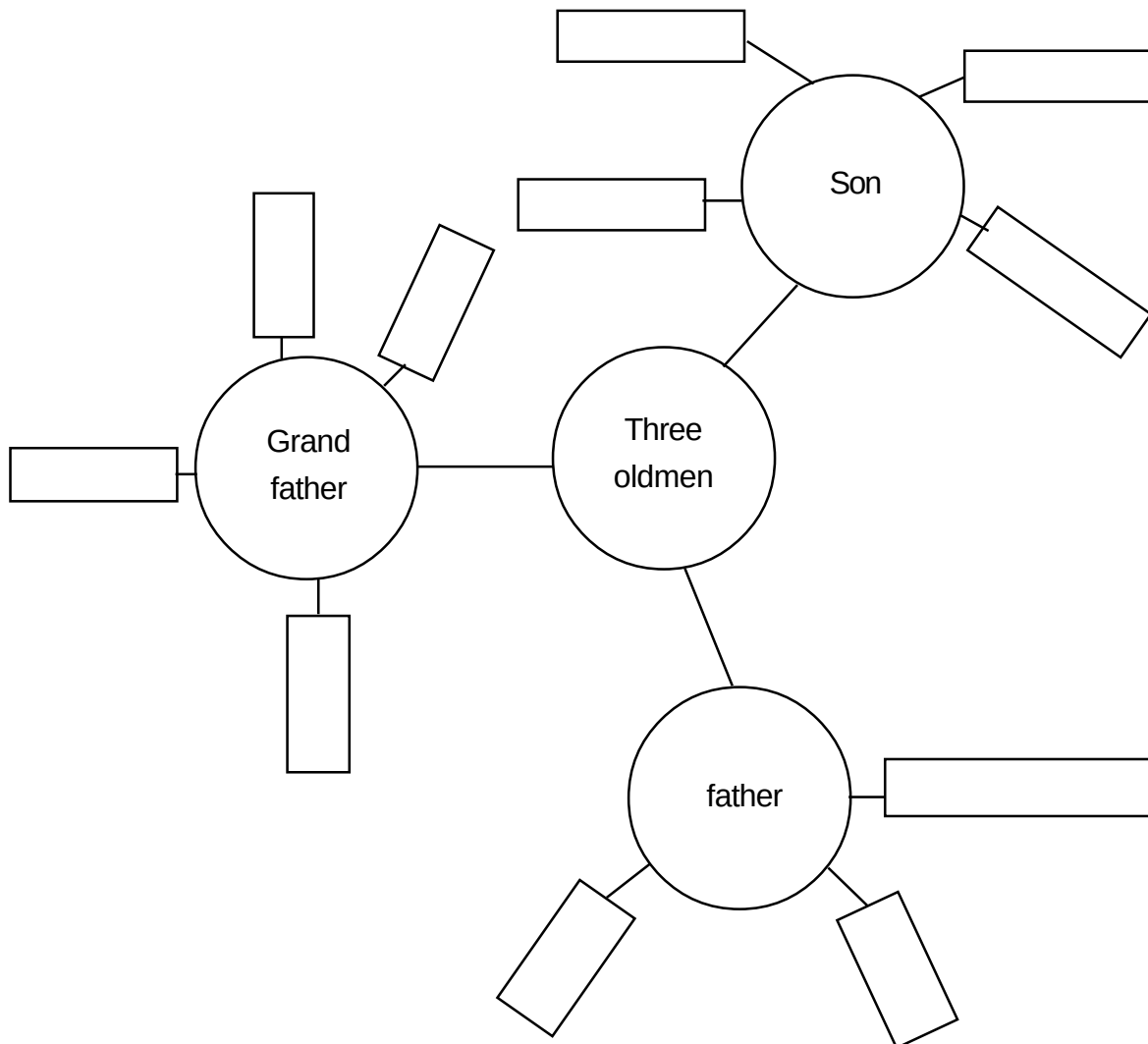
Answer the following questions in about fifty words.

1. How did the grain of corn reach the king ?
2. How did the wise men know that it was a grain of corn ?
3. What suggestions did the learned men give to the king to find out when and where such corns had grown ?
4. What were the replies given by the old peasant and his father regarding the corn ?
5. How were the three old men in the story described ?
6. Briefly describe the life style of the people during grandfather's time.
7. What comments did the grandfather give on the life style of people today?

E. Activity :

1. Draw a family tree using the information given in the story.
 - (a) Here are some words and expressions given in the box. Choose the right words / expressions and fill in the following diagram.

toothless, one crutch, eyes clear, old and bent, two crutches, without crutches, heard better, spoke distinctly, ashy pale still able to see, hearing good.



- (b) Now use the words and expressions in your own sentences to describe the three oldmen. Then arrange the sentences in order of the story.

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